

TRANSHUMANCE FLOW MONITORING — CRR-S, CRR-N, NBR, LRR REGIONS, THE GAMBIA



Context & Background

In The Gambia, tensions between farmers and herders – particularly in the Central River Region South (CRR-S), Central River Region North (CRR-N), North Bank Region (NBR), and Lower River Region (LRR) – have intensified due to climate change, environmental degradation, and socio-economic pressures. Reduced rainfall and desertification have increased competition over land and water resource, placing both agricultural and pastoral livelihoods under stress.

Transhumance, the seasonal movement of livestock in search of pasture and water, remains a key livelihood strategy. However, it is increasingly challenged by resource scarcity and cross-border movements, mainly between. The Gambia and Senegal, which place additional pressure on host communities.

The International Organization for Migration (IOM), through its Displacement Tracking Matrix (DTM), has developed the Transhumance Tracking Tool (TTT). The TTT monitors transhumance movements through a network of trained enumerators and key informants, collecting data on livestock flows, routes, and related risks. This approach aims to strengthen the capacity of national and local stakeholders to better understand transhumance dynamics, support evidence-based decision-making, and contribute to conflict prevention and early warning mechanisms.

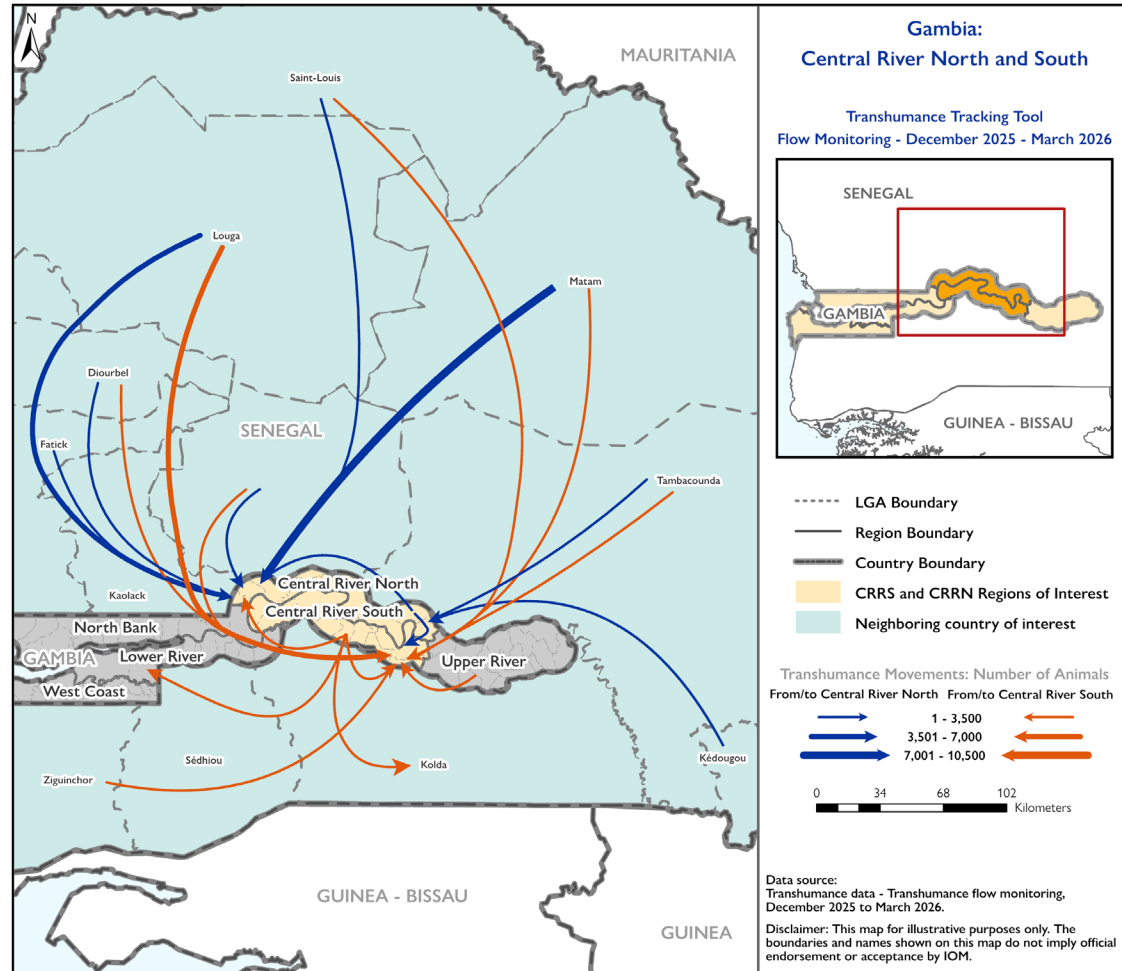
This report presents findings from data collected between December 2025 and March 2026 across ten Flow Monitoring Points (FMPs) in CRR-S, CRR-N, NBR, and LRR. Data collection was conducted through direct observation and interviews by DTM enumerators, with financial support from the United Nations Peacebuilding Fund (PBF).

Transhumance movements observed during the reporting period follow seasonal patterns, with herders – primarily from Senegal as well as within The Gambia – moving during the dry season in search of water and pasture. These movements are often strategically coordinated, with family members traveling ahead to assess security conditions before herds are relocated.

During the reporting period, a total of 2,222 herders were recorded across the four regions, with the highest numbers observed in CRR-N and CRR-S. The majority of herders (90%) were Senegalese nationals, while 10 per cent were Gambian. Similarly, 90 per cent of recorded livestock movements were cross-border, highlighting the strong regional dimension of transhumance in The Gambia.

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Map 1: Transhumance flows through Central River Region North and South to intended regions of destination



Central River Region –North Overview

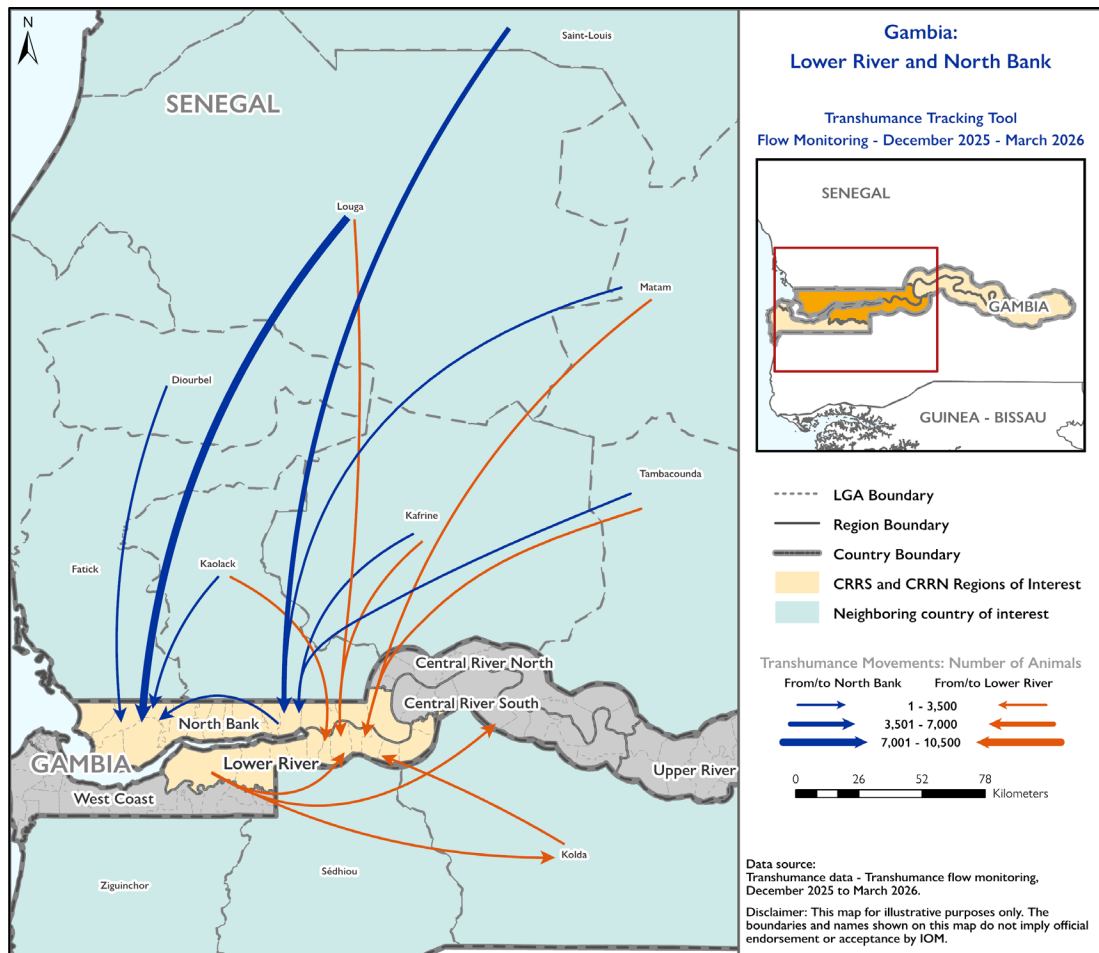
Total Herders	1,034
Total Animals	23,111
Flow Monitoring Points	2
Nationalities of herders	Gambian (1%) & Senegalese (99%)

Central River Region –South Overview

Total Herders	535
Total Animals	17,224
Flow Monitoring Points	3
Nationality of herders	Gambian (37%) & Senegalese (63%)

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Map 1: Transhumance flows through LOWER River Region and North Bank Region to intended regions of destination



Lower River Region Overview

Total Herders	102
Total Animals	, 2,194
Flow Monitoring Points	2
Nationalities of herders	Gambian (56%) & Senegalese (44%)

North Bank Region Overview

Total Herders	551
Total Animals	16,978
Flow Monitoring Points	3
Nationality of herders	Gambian (81%) & Senegalese (19%)

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Origin and Intended Destination of Herds

Movements
Within Gambia
Gambia → Gambia
5,289
animals
9 per cent of total
movements

Cross-border
Movements
Gambia → Senegal
76
animals
< 1 per cent of cross-border
movements

Cross-border
Movements
Senegal ↔ Senegal
1,242
animals
2 per cent of total
movements

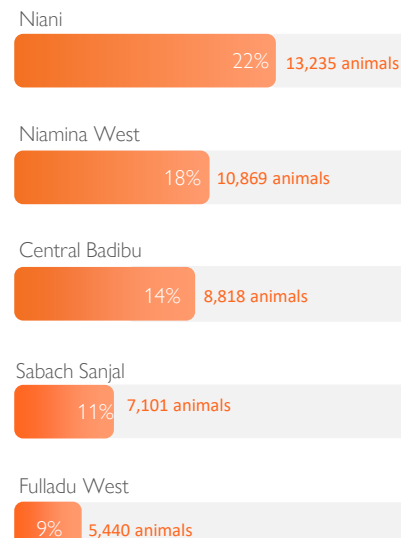
Cross-border
Movements
Senegal → Gambia
52,360
animals
88 per cent of cross-border
movements

In-country movements represented 9 per cent (5,289 animals), reflecting herders moving livestock between regions within The Gambia. Cross-border movements accounted for 1 per cent from The Gambia to Senegal (76 animals). Most recorded movements were from Senegal to The Gambia (52,360 animals), while 2 per cent (1,242 animals) involved movements within Senegal.

The strong incoming flow highlights cross-border movements – particularly from Senegal – where herders strategically bring livestock into The Gambia in response to seasonal conditions such as pasture availability and water access. This directional pattern underscores the interconnected nature of pastoral systems across the sub-region and the importance of coordinated, cross-border management and monitoring.

Top Intended Destination Districts for Animal Movements

Figure 1. Top destination District for animal movements*



Niani emerged as the leading intended destination for transhumance movements over the four-month period from December 2025 to March 2026, receiving 22 per cent of all recorded flows. This suggests that Niani is part of an established seasonal movement corridor, likely driven by the availability of suitable pasture and water resources in the area during this period.

Note: Percentages reflect only the top five intended destinations and therefore do not sum to 100 per cent, as movements were also recorded to other districts not shown in the chart.

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Movements Within Gambia

In-country movements represented 9 per cent (5,289 animals), indicating that a notable share of transhumance takes place within The Gambia. The most frequently recorded route was from Sinchu Chedoyel to Jareng (413 animals). Other common routes included Sambang to Karantaba (400 animals) and Sukuta to Wassu (338 animals), pointing to regular livestock movements across districts within the Central River Region (North and South).

These patterns suggest that pastoralist routes are shaped by seasonal conditions and the availability of pasture and water. Overall, the findings highlight the importance of established transhumance corridors in The Gambia and the long-standing reliance of pastoral communities on predictable movement pathways.

Table 1. Movement flow within Gambia

Locality of departure	Locality of destination	Herders Recorded	Total Animals
Sinchu Chedoyel	Jareng	16	413
Sambang	Karantaba	6	400
Sukuta	Wassu	13	338
Sinchu Chedoyel	Kudanga	22	320
Yalali samba	Moriya	6	280
Kerr Pateh Korreh	Kerr Pateh Korreh	8	204
Sinchu Chedoyel	Sambel Kunda	13	180
Jimara	Sinchang	3	180
Faraba	Dankunku	10	165
Dasilameh	Dasilameh	3	150
Doffa	Sambel Kunda	2	150
Sinchu Chedoyel	Gissadi	7	147
Malikunda sambang cluster	Jabisa	5	143

Cross-border Movements

Cross-border transhumance within the Senegambia region is a significant herding practice. Over the four-month period from December 2025 to March 2026, a total of 52,436 animals and 1,960 herders were recorded moving between Senegal and The Gambia.

These movements represented 88 per cent of all tracked animals and 88 per cent of all tracked herders. The flow was strongly directional: 76 animals and six herders moved from The Gambia to Senegal (1% of tracked animals and less than 1% of tracked herders), while 52,360 animals and 1,954 herders moved from Senegal to The Gambia (88% of tracked animals and 87% of tracked herders).

The high volume of movements from Senegal into The Gambia suggests that herders are entering The Gambia to access seasonal resources, including available pasture and water points. By contrast, outward movements from The Gambia to Senegal were minimal during the reporting period.

Senegal - Gambia (Top 6 movement)

Daru Musty → Kerr Pateh Korreh

4974

Animals

146

Herders

Matam → Wassu

1,112

Animals

76

Herders

Louga → Wassu

1,115

Animals

68

Herders

Wellingarai → Jimbara

416

Animals

57

Herders

Dumbul Daka → Jimbara

603

Animals

35

Herders

Chalice Bubacarr → Raneru

910

Animals

30

Herders

Gambia to Senegal (Top 3 movement)

Jokul → Neypee

40

Animals

3

Herders

Jokul → Anumani

26

Animals

2

Herders

Teskera foras → Wassu

10

Animals

1

Herders

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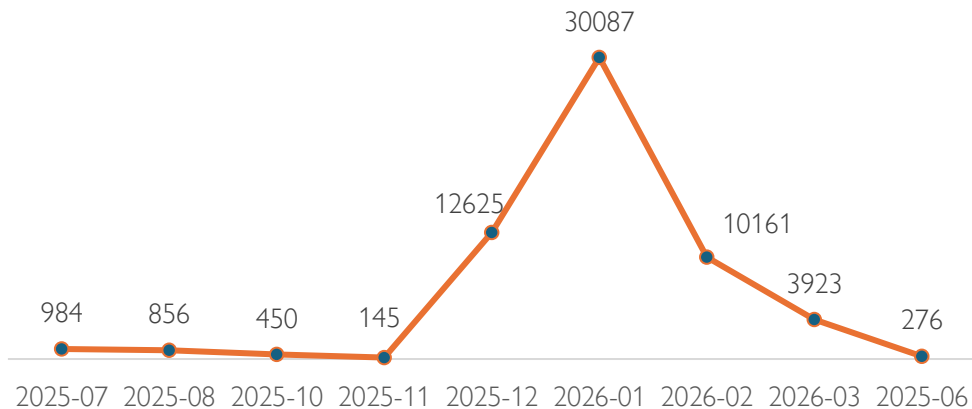
Evolution of Observed Flows

Observed herd departures show a clear monthly pattern, increasing significantly from 276 animals in June 2025 to a peak of 30,087 animals in January 2026, before declining over the following two months to 3,923 animals in March 2026. This trend suggests a strong seasonal movement pattern, with departures rising steadily before reaching their highest level at the start of 2026.

This pattern reflects a **sharp rise to the January 2026 peak followed by a decline**. The latest monthly flow was **61 per cent lower than the previous month**, confirming the recent slowdown in departures.

Projected returns suggest that most herds are expected to return after more than two months (over 8 weeks), representing 43 per cent of animals. The second-largest category is “does not know,” accounting for 38 per cent of animals, which indicates a high level of uncertainty around return timing. Among the known shorter return periods, the largest share is expected between 6 and 8 weeks (around 2 months), covering 13 per cent of animals. Overall, this suggests that herd returns are likely to be concentrated over a longer timeframe, while uncertainty remains significant for a large proportion of movements.

Figure 2. Date of departure of animals



PEAK DEPARTURE MONTH

January 2026

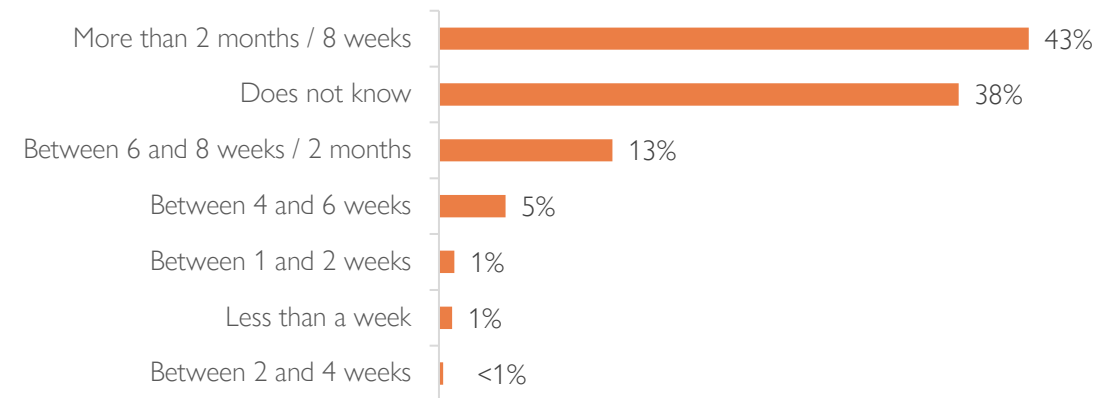
30,087 animals

DEPARTURE PERIOD

10 Months

June 2025–Mar 2026

Figure 3. Date of Return of animals



PEAK RETURN

Over 8 weeks

25,386 animals

RETURN TIMELINE

Over 8 Weeks

Note: Due to rounding errors percentages can sum up to +/- 1 100 per cent

Methodology

Data were collected through direct interviews, field observations, and key informant interviews conducted by DTM enumerators, and triangulated with information obtained from a network of informants, including community members.

Following the transhumance baseline and infrastructure mapping, movements were recorded and monitored across 10 designated transhumance flow monitoring points: 3 in North Bank Region, 2 in Central River Region-North (CRR-N), 4 in Central River Region South (CRR-South) and 1 in LRR.

The Data collected included transhumant herders' country and region of departures, intended destinations, date of departures, estimated date of arrival, herd species, and the number of animals recorded at each monitoring point.

The data were analyzed to quantify transhumance movements and to identify key trends, patterns, and findings related to seasonal herd mobility in the region

The results were subsequently compiled into this report to provide evidence-based analysis of transhumance movements and return patterns.



Transhumance tracking in Kerr Pateh Kora, North Bank Region. © IOM, The Gambia 2026